Your own chatbot to pay your bills? Or to lodge a complaint? Or to file your taxes? And all on WhatsApp? The future is already here. All it needs is for more people to board that train and for its compartments to be made of tough but completely transparent glass. The government began the process of putting a digital public infrastructure (DPI) in place a long ago. And this has played a massive role in boosting economic growth and social inclusivity. However, the country needs to breach the vast digital divide: basic universal e-literacy is a precondition for everyone participating in the country's digital revolution. Before that, however, what will be needed is a concerted strategy, trained manpower, durable networks and sustained investment.

WHY IT IS A GAME CHANGER

India's digital public infrastructure has powered the growth of digital services, fostered innovation and enhanced productivity and efficiency in the public sector. Initiatives such as Aadhaar for digital identity, UMANG (Unified Mobile Application for New-age Governance), Unified Payments Interface (UPI) for online payments, Government e-Marketplace (GeM) for public procurement, mSeva and DigiLocker have fundamentally changed the way government agencies facilitate ease of living for citizens.

However, the uniform distribution of such services continues to be a concern. Besides, not all states or agencies have the resources or infrastructure to build equally efficient digital platforms. It's important, therefore, that best practices are shared everywhere. Take, for instance, the Urban Platform for deliverY of Online Governance (UPYOG) of the National Urban Digital Mission (NUDM), which facilitates the electronic delivery of municipal services to citizens across the towns and cities of the country. The NUDM's mandate is to make available shared digital infrastructure, foundational digital building blocks, ready-to-use platforms, standards, specifications and frameworks for electronic delivery of municipal services to all states and Union Territories.



"Equal and mutually respectful partnerships between governments and civil society in using civic technology holds out immense possibilities for transforming democracy and governance. The Swachhata mobile app and www.cityfinance.in are examples of such partnerships"

– SRIKANTH VISWANATHAN
Chief Executive Officer, Janaagraha

UPYOG has been built using DIGIT, so that civic agencies in every corner of the country can adapt the platform to their own specific requirements. The objective is that every city or town can access the same technology without having to build its own.

The mode of usage also determines the efficiency of certain services. Government digital services, unlike car aggregator services or food apps, are not used frequently. Most people, therefore, don't download apps related to these services on their mobile phones. Several state governments have now come up with innovative ways to make such services user-friendly. For instance, in Punjab, several citizen-centric mobile apps hosted under the mSeva app store, developed by C-DAC under the guidance of the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, are now available through WhatsApp. A WhatsApp chat bot helps people in routine tasks like paying electricity bills or filing civic complaints. Similarly, the Kurnool Municipal Corporation in Andhra Pradesh also uses a WhatsApp chatbot to deliver services to citizens.

WHAT INDIA NEEDS TO MASTER

A recent working paper by the International Monetary Fund (IMF) acknowledged that India's challenge is to scale up the reach of its digital public infrastructure as the vast majority of the country's citizens remain deprived of internet access or digital services.

The government must, therefore, now increase expenditure in building digital infrastructure in areas that fall in an umbral zone. Besides, it must encourage more public-private collaborations for developing low-cost and localised digital platforms that are meant for e-governance. It will have to do better than the 2023-24 Union budget allocation of Rs 4,795 crore for Digital India, which is 37 per cent lower than last year's actual outlay of Rs 7,603 crore. ■

THE CHANGE-MAKERS

NATIONAL URBAN DIGITAL MISSION

Builds digital infrastructure to increase the scale, speed and capacity of the urban ecosystem

DIGITAL INDIA CORPORATION

A non-profit set up by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology to drive the Digital India mission